

Objective list theories believe in objective prudential goods: that is, being a couch potato can bring joy, but only experiencing virtuous activities can bring happiness (Haybron, 2020). Nevertheless, individuals still have subjective understandings of objective goods. For instance, perfectionism believes perfecting human nature constitutes one's happiness (Crisp, 2017), and Aristotelians believe achieving eudaimonia needs the fulfillment of human capacities (Haybron, 2020).

Based on this understanding of happiness, I argue that one's happiness cannot be measured. That is because the two necessary processes involved in measurement are impossible to be satisfied, which are:

Process I. Respondents have a clear understanding of their personal happiness (I - inner)

Process II. They convey their sense of happiness accurately and completely to externality (inner-outer)

The following essay will examine these two processes.

Process I: Realization of the self

Lao-Tzu believes that "He who knows himself is enlightened (Laozi, 2018)." Knowing oneself is fully discovering one's feelings, thoughts, and beliefs (Gertler, 2020). Since happiness is subjectively perceived as forms above, one first needs to understand what is his/her knowing, or at least what makes him/her approach knowing. With this benchmark, one can then roughly evaluate how far is he/she away from knowing.

Because happiness blends inseparably with physical sensation, one's knowledge of externality will first affect knowing. To learn the external world, Locke writes, "Tis therefore the actual receiving the ideas from without that gives us notice of the existence of other

things (Rockwood, 2018)." That means the knowledge about externality doesn't build from established beliefs toward externality but is from our raw sensation. To discern these two sources, individuals' perception needs to be a "dynamic searching for the best interpretation of available data" (Gregory, 2015), and I interpret this search as self-consciousness.

Being self-conscious takes two steps. By invoking System II¹ (i.e., slow but logical mind), individuals first direct their attention to effortful mental activities and once autopilot behaviors, providing a threshold for gaining subjective experiences (Kahneman, 2011). Nearly simultaneously, metacognition involves monitoring one's cognitive states, ensuring individuals view their thoughts critically. System II and metacognition push an individual to the boundary of known, and the process of taking the unknown into the known is self-conscious.

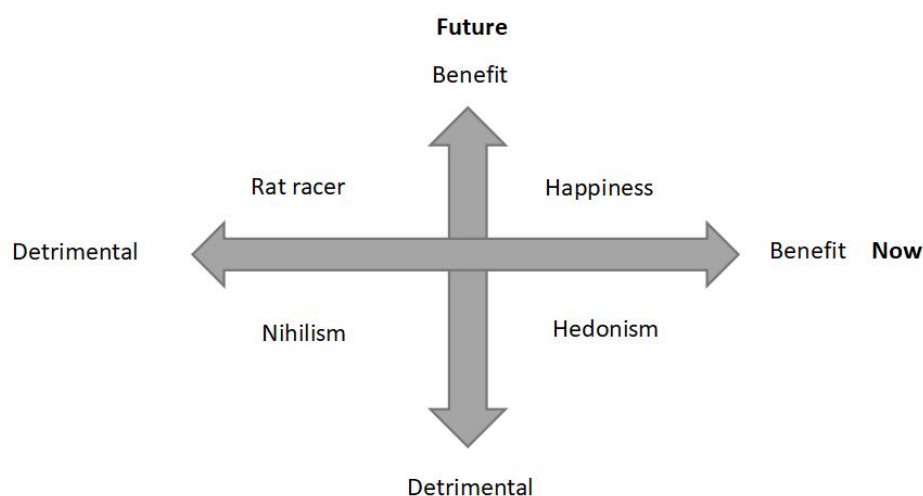
However, barriers hinder human beings from discovering the self. Biologically speaking, human beings have a natural tendency to conserve energy and thus evade the activation of System II, especially on tasks that can be automatically processed by System I² (fast but prone-to-bias mind) (Kahneman, 2011). Moreover, individuals can fail to realize that their attention to externality is virtually divided. As Corteen and Wood (1972) discovered, when words didn't consciously perceive by participants, they still established meaning in their minds. With all barriers to realizing the self, Kant says a man cannot "determine with certainty what would make him truly happy; because to do so he would need to be omniscient (Kant, 1889)."

The idea of being omniscient is to transcend and discover one's essential state of happiness. However, even if a being believes he/she attains a sense of happiness, it may be a

fallacy and not the knowing. To illustrate this claim, I adopt Tal Ben-Shahar's (2007) model and analyze possible cognitive limitations hindering each archetype's transcendence. Every individual who forms a belief to present and future happiness can fall into a quadrant.

Figure 1

*The four quadrant*³



Hedonism

By taking psychoactive drugs and performing religious behaviors, human beings can intentionally alter their states of consciousness (Cacioppo & Freberg, 2019). With this artificial change of beliefs, hedonistic drug takers regard instant satisfaction as happiness and disregard their future. However, if happiness exists in the form of eudaimonia, the overall achievement in life is related to one's level of happiness (Warburton, 2012). Since hedonists blind future possible happiness, transcendence can only occur when they realize the mistake of regarding instant excitement as ultimate happiness.

Nihilism

During World War II, numerous people failed into learned helplessness and believed they lost both present and future happiness. According to Karl Jasper's theory, they fail into a "limit situation," believing that only the external locus of control exists (Valdes-Stauber, 2016). However, a "limit situation" can "becomes one's destination in the realization of one's existence," provoking people to ask for higher happiness (Jacobsen, 2008). Frankl (2006) accepted his unavoidable sufferings bravely, believing meaning is inherent in experiences. People with severe chronic diseases learn to adapt to their impairments and transcend themselves (Charmaz, 1995). Thus, if the higher happiness integrates the meaning of pain, nihilists evaluate their happiness based on their "existence" rather than their "essence" (Sartre, 1946), disregarding the potential of transitoriness.

Happiness

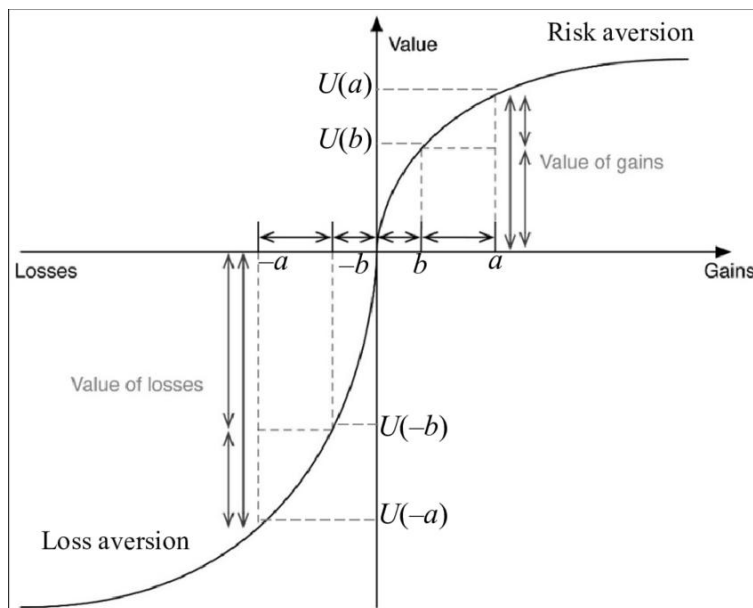
Happiness is the archetype with the highest possibility of approaching the knowing since they believe they can discover one's maxim of happiness for now and the future. With the belief to transcend, they take happiness more as a dynamic skill that detaches from established experience. However, if the perception turns to an explicit rating within oneself, possible bias may occur while constructing the frame. For instance, about what contributes to one's happiness, individuals take certain aspects as the primary cause, but the ignored intricate associations among these aspects are also essential for gaining happiness. As Gestalt psychology illustrated, one's understanding "seems to depend upon relations among the stimuli rather than upon the individual stimuli as such (Kohler, 1967)." Therefore, the transition between perception and evaluation can undermine the known.

Rat Racer

Rat racers "subordinate the present to the future" and "suffer now for some anticipated gain" (Tal Ben-Shahar, 2007), regarding their sacrifice in present happiness is meaningful. However, this destiny-orientated pursuit ignores the impact of the shift in reference points. Under this "finite game" (Carse, 2012), rat racers keep aiming for a higher reference point and leave themselves in a state of loss. Due to loss aversion, the same amount of gain from the past and loss from now cannot subjectively offset each other (Kahneman, 2011). Without possible transcending, which is to gain happiness from journeys, rat racers accumulate their loss and search for happiness continuously in the wrong direction.

Figure 2

The utility function ⁵



Overall, because of the difficulty of approaching knowing and one's cognitive limitation, it is nearly impossible to achieve the process I.

Process II: The interaction between internality and externality

Having discussed the near-impossibility of knowing one's own happiness, I now turn to the challenges one faces in conveying their happiness rating to an external entity should one

miraculously attain an accurate self-rating, i.e., Process II. Two conditions are needed to satisfy Process II:

Condition I. Individuals are willing to convey their understanding of externality fully and accurately

Condition II. Externality constructs a frame that can capture individuals' understanding comprehensively

Firstly, for Condition I, tests' intention strongly affects individuals' willingness. If the test aims to achieve the externality's purpose, such as collecting data for scientific research, moderate anonymity facilitates authenticity by lowering social desirability pressures (Lelkes et al., 2012). However, if the respondents regard the measurement as a way of knowing themselves, one essential question arises: Can a man be honest to himself when he/she stays alone?

The existence of cognitive dissonance undermines respondents' willingness to convey their understanding. For rat racers, reporting "happy" (action) allows respondents to stay consistent with the social expectation of wealth and fame (belief), even though they realize the lack of happiness. Moreover, under the value system that "unhappiness is a symptom of maladjustment" (Frankl, 2006), respondents may hide their willingness further to conform to social desirability and reduce their cognitive dissonance.

Secondly, an effective frame should first capture **all** respondents' understandings to satisfy Condition II. Therefore, researchers use "meaning" in tests without clarification or a broad definition such as "as the sense made of" (Steger et al., 2006). However, the lack of

precision means respondents' understanding must be clear. If Process I fails, then Condition II will be hard to achieve.

Alternatively, the test can be more precise by including potential factors, such as "non-hedonic sources of happiness and suffering (Stone et al.,2013)." Nevertheless, precision can bring more challenges. For instance, overcoming challenges can bring competence, which is normally regarded as a promoter of happiness. But competence cannot enhance their happiness if respondents feel a lack of autonomy while handling the tasks (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Therefore, if the measurement improves the evaluation by incorporating more correlated sources, such as competence, it should take even more correlated factors to ensure the test is unbiased.

Not only does the trade-off between broadness and precision bring a challenge, but the cognition of society also limits the frame of the test. Influenced by culture, measurement in a collectivist society attaches more importance to contributions toward groups, likely to regard these efforts are more eudaimonic than personal growth. Influenced by the features of an era, society's understanding of happiness diverges with individuals'. For instance, in the Song Dynasty of China (960-1279 A.D.), Su Tungpo spoke truth to power and thus was exiled to undeveloped land such as Lingnan. Even though he suffered, he still perceived a strong sense of happiness, expressing that in his poem: "With three hundred litchis every day and night; I am willing to be a Lingnan man for the rest of my life (Lin, 2018).” Society aims to suppress him and reduce his happiness, but Tungpo "amor fati"--loves his fate (Han-Pile, 2009). The diverged understandings between individual and externality mean that if the externality constructs a measurement, it would be biased.

More importantly, it is hard to realize that one's understanding of happiness differs from society's. For instance, it is convincing that social connection can promote the development of self-esteem (Maslow, 1943), but is it possible that society overly reinforces the role of externality on one's happiness? Under the encouragement of social networks, individuals may falsely regard solitude as loneliness, internalizing society's value and veiling their personal understandings. Society believes tests such as subjective well-being shows strong convergent validity (Stone et al., 2013), but is this testing individuals' *subjective* well-being? Or is it more about society-encouraged well-being?

Conclusion

This essay argues that happiness cannot be measured by examining two processes.

First, an individual must approach knowing to establish a benchmark for subjective measurement. However, staying self-conscious is arduous; additionally, possible cognitive limitations and conversion from beliefs to evaluation can hinder the process of knowing. Thus, Process I is hard to be satisfied with.

Second, respondents' willingness to convey and the test's frame determine the effectiveness of Process II. Respectively, cognitive dissonance undermines one's willingness to convey, and the trade-off between broadness and preciseness brings challenges to constructing the frame. Moreover, since society's and individuals' understanding of happiness diverges, the frame constructed by externality measures socially desired well-being rather than subjective well-being.

In the future, intricate biological approaches and perfected measurements have the potential to reflect one's state accurately, but how far the state is away from happiness can

only be certain when one approaches the state of knowing, the benchmark of subjectively-perceived happiness. Luckily, with the effort to measure happiness, society begins to reflect on what strongly contribute to individuals' happiness and how society plays a role in every being's life, which is already an invaluable gift.

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Footnotes

¹ According to Kahneman (2011), System II in mind "allocates attention to the effortful mental activities that demand it."

² According to Kahneman (2011), System I in mind " operates automatically and quickly, with little or no effort and no sense of voluntary control."

³ The image is from Tal Ben-Shahar. (2007). *Happier: learn the secrets to daily joy and lasting fulfillment*. McGraw-Hill.

⁴ According to Carse (2012), a finite game is "played for the purpose of winning"; oppositely, an infinite game is "for the purpose of continuing the play."

⁵ The absolute value of $U(-a)$ is greater than $U(a)$, which means the subjective gain obtained from $(a+b)$ cannot offset the subjective loss brought by $-(a+b)$. This figure is from Khalil, T. E., Albastaki, F., Obaid, L., Zaid, H. A., Dalalah, D., & Alhassani, S. (2022). Ranking Risk Attitudes Using an Integrated AHP-TOPSIS Approach. *International Journal of Applied Decision Sciences*, 1(1), 1. <https://doi.org/10.1504/ijads.2022.10037216>.